More People Are Using Their Library Cards

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When money is tight, many people turn to the library. Izzy Rivera lives in Topeka, Kansas. She reads at least one book every week. But she is saving money for **law school**, so she cannot always buy new books. "Say I'm buying a few a month," she said. "It just isn't realistic." So Rivera borrows books from her library. Last month she bought 15 used books for about $20 at a library book sale. "It's somewhere I can go where I'm not expected to spend money," she said. A **survey** found that 44% of Americans had trouble paying for a basic need last year, and 70% cut back on extras like **streaming**. Big libraries across the country say more people are joining, borrowing books and coming to events. In Los Angeles, use of the library's **makerspace** grew 37%. Libraries lend more than books. Many lend Wi-Fi **hotspots**, cooking tools, bird-watching kits and camping gear. But library money is under pressure: last year, the Trump administration tried to cut **funding**, but 21 states went to court and the money was saved.

Word Treasure

survey -- A survey is a set of questions asked to learn what people think.
makerspace -- A makerspace is a room where people can build and make things.
hotspots -- A hotspot lets a device connect to the internet.
streaming -- Streaming means watching or listening over the internet.
funding -- Funding is money given to pay for something.
law school -- Law school is a school where people study to become lawyers.

Background you need

A public library lets anyone borrow books for free.

When money is tight, free things help families save.

Break it down

WHO: Izzy Rivera and library users across the country
WHAT: More people are using libraries as money gets tight
WHERE: Topeka, Los Angeles, Chicago and other cities
WHY: Libraries are free, and prices are rising

Why it matters

Your library card can get you books, movies and tools for free, which helps when money is tight at home.

Test what you remember

1. Where does Izzy Rivera live?

- (A) Phoenix, Arizona
- (B) Los Angeles, California
- (C) Chicago, Illinois
- (D) Topeka, Kansas

2. How many books did Rivera buy at the library book sale?

- (A) 5 books for about $20
- (B) 20 books for about $15
- (C) 10 books for about $30
- (D) 15 books for about $20

3. What did the survey find?

- (A) 70% of Americans moved house
- (B) 44% of Americans stopped reading
- (C) 44% of Americans had trouble paying for a basic need
- (D) 70% of Americans bought more books

4. By how much did use of the Los Angeles library's makerspace grow?

- (A) 11%
- (B) 37%
- (C) 20%
- (D) 8%

5. What do libraries lend besides books?

- (A) Wi-Fi hotspots, cooking tools, bird-watching kits and camping gear
- (B) Pets
- (C) Clothes and shoes
- (D) Cars and boats

6. What happened when the government tried to cut library funding?

- (A) Nothing happened
- (B) Libraries lost all their money
- (C) All libraries closed
- (D) 21 states went to court and the money was saved

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Izzy Rivera: says the library is a place where she is not expected to spend money

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):